China's economic opening and growth under Deng Xiaoping's leadership from the late 1970s was supported by the country's access to the financial resources from the World Bank for building infrastructure, and by economic, financial, and technical expertise from the IMF. In most circumstances, however, China maintained a low profile in global financial governance matters.[14] China's *taoguang yanghui* (which roughly translates to "hide your capabilities and bide your time") strategy, following Deng's wisdom, continued to dominate China's stance on global financial governance well into the early 2000s. With the exception of China's misgivings about the IMF's handling of the Asian financial crisis, the Chinese authorities did not overtly express either strong interest in or serious disagreement with the major powers in the international financial institutions before 2005.[15] Since then, one can identify several reasons for increased tension; among these are the breakdown of Article IV (exchange rate) consultations with the IMF due to the IMF's pressure for RMB revaluation,[16] the IMF's open criticism of China's global "savings glut,"[17] and concerns over excessively loose monetary and fiscal policies conducted by the United States that intensified the volatility of the dollar-dominant global economy.[18] Behind these tensions over global imbalances lies the inescapable fact that the Chinese economy, particularly since the late 1990s, has become irreversibly integrated into the global economy through its trade and investment around the world, and changes in global economic conditions also have begun to affect China's own economy.[19] At the same time, one may note China's renewed interest in its own heritage as a prominent power in global financial governance going back seventy years, as policymakers called on this legacy when addressing the need for fair representation of developing countries, as well as the imperative for the Bretton Woods institutions to serve as entities of "resource mobilization and transfer" from the rich regions to the poor.[20] These calls made by China predated the BRICs formation.

The quick ascent of the Chinese economy and expansion of its economic influence around the world was already visible prior to the crises of the late 2000s, as the advanced economies were struck by the subprime mortgage crisis (2007) and subsequent global financial crisis (2008–2009).[21] These crises, nonetheless, opened up more space for the Chinese government to be proactive in challenging global financial governance, as discussed next.